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COVER REPORT / DIPLOMACY / MIDDLE EAST

Eight Foreign Ministers Meet in Istanbul to Seek De-escalation

Pakistan joined Türkiye, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and four European states for talks on regional conflicts, maritime routes and the economic cost of escalation.

AT A GLANCE — FIVE DEVELOPMENTS

01 EIGHT-NATION TALKS

Pakistan joined regional and European ministers in Istanbul to discuss ways to contain conflict.

02 WHEAT PRICE SIGNAL

Islamabad set an indicative 2027 wheat price of Rs4,500 per 40kg.

03 ESSENTIAL-ITEM INFLATION

The PBS weekly price index rose 0.65% from the previous week.

04 GLOBAL OIL ALERT

Brent briefly touched $115 a barrel amid Middle East supply concerns.

05 VACCINE RESEARCH

WHO said the TUMAINI vaccine trial began enrolling participants in the DRC.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, foreign ministers of Türkiye, Egypt, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia met in Istanbul, then held expanded talks with France, Germany, Italy and the United Kingdom. Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Mohammad Ishaq Dar joined consultations on Middle East conflicts, humanitarian access and the economic effects of insecurity.

The R4 joint statement urged dialogue over the US-Israel-Iran conflict, safe navigation through the Strait of Hormuz, civilian protection and progress towards a two-state settlement for Palestine. Pakistan's Press Information Department said the eight ministers agreed to continue engagement. No ceasefire or binding maritime security arrangement was announced.

EXAM ANGLE / International Relations: regional diplomacy; Current Affairs: Gulf shipping. [1] [2] [3]

BACKGROUND

The R4 comprises Türkiye, Egypt, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia. The Istanbul meeting then added foreign ministers from four European states.

ANALYSIS

For Pakistan, secure Gulf shipping matters for energy imports, freight and food supplies. Follow-up diplomacy must deliver practical support for navigation and negotiations.

REVISION / THREE POINTS

01 R4 members: Türkiye, Egypt, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia.

02 The expanded meeting added France, Germany, Italy and the UK.

03 No ceasefire or binding agreement was announced.

01 PAKISTAN

ECONOMY / FOREIGN POLICY / SECURITY / GOVERNANCE

MARKET INDICATORS / LATEST REPORTED

SBP POLICY RATE	USD / PKR	KSE-100
11.50%	277.02	162,374.87
14 September 2026 • last MPC	23 October 2026 • interbank offer	23 October 2026 • index close

Rate: State Bank of Pakistan • Currency: Business Recorder • Equities: Mettis Global [4] [5] [6]

SECURITY / FOREIGN POLICY

Pakistan and Saudi Arabia Complete Defence Pact Ratification

The Foreign Office said both countries had finished their domestic approval processes; Türkiye's ratification remained pending.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, Pakistan's Foreign Office reported that Pakistan and Saudi Arabia had completed ratification procedures for the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement. Spokesperson Sajjad Haider Khan told reporters that Türkiye was still undertaking its domestic procedure. He described the agreement as defensive in character and consistent with the United Nations Charter.

The agreement had been signed in August by Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye. According to the reported text, an armed attack on one participant is regarded as an attack on all. The spokesperson said details of implementation and operation were still being discussed by the partners, including through their Strategic Political and Defence Committee.

During separate Istanbul talks on the same day, Ishaq Dar and Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan discussed regional security and their coordination under the Makkah agreement. The evolving situation around attacks on Saudi Arabia gave the pact immediate diplomatic importance. The stated completion of two ratifications, however, should not be confused with a claim that all three members had finished the legal process.

BACKGROUND

Ratification is the domestic and international procedure by which a state formally confirms its consent to be bound by an agreement. The legal steps can differ between parliamentary and executive systems; the Pakistani spokesperson stressed that each member follows its own process.

ANALYSIS

Collective-defence commitments can increase deterrence but also create difficult questions about decision-making, use of force and escalation. For Pakistan, clarity over consultations, legal authorisation and the scope of defensive assistance will shape how the pact functions in any future crisis.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Pakistan and Saudi Arabia were reported to have completed ratification.

02 Türkiye had not completed its domestic ratification on 23 October.

03 The Foreign Office characterised the Makkah agreement as defensive.

EXAM ANGLE / Pakistan Affairs — foreign and security policy; International Relations — alliances and collective security. [7] [8]

AGRICULTURE / FOOD SECURITY

Government Sets Indicative Wheat Price at Rs4,500 per Maund

The proposed 2027 price is Rs1,000 above the earlier benchmark, with growers' costs and sowing incentives cited as reasons.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif announced an indicative wheat price of Rs4,500 per maund, or 40 kilograms, for 2027. The Prime Minister's Office said the figure represented an increase of Rs1,000 from last year's Rs3,500 benchmark. It presented the proposed price as a response to rising diesel, fertiliser and other production costs faced by cultivators.

BACKGROUND

A maund is conventionally expressed as 40 kilograms in Pakistan's wheat policy discussions. An indicative price signals policy intent; it is analytically distinct from a guaranteed purchase of every unit produced at that price.

ANALYSIS

The decision illustrates a core agricultural-policy trade-off. Better farm-gate incentives can support planting and production, while expensive wheat can place pressure on flour prices and vulnerable consumers. Credible implementation requires attention to procurement capacity, competition and targeted household protection.

The announcement followed consultation with federal and provincial political leaders. The government said a stronger price signal could encourage wheat cultivation in the coming season, protect growers' income and reduce reliance on external purchases. It also linked agricultural incentives to the wider objective of domestic food security.

An indicative figure is not evidence that all farmers will actually receive Rs4,500 in every market. The outcome will depend on the final procurement framework, local demand, the amount of government buying, crop conditions and farmers' access to inputs. Dawn reported that an agricultural group had sought Rs5,000 per maund, leaving a visible gap between the announced figure and that demand.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Indicative 2027 wheat price: Rs4,500 per 40 kg.

02 Increase over the earlier benchmark: Rs1,000 per 40 kg.

03 The price is indicative; its market effect depends on implementation.

EXAM ANGLE / Pakistan Affairs — agriculture and food security; Economics — price incentives and market intervention. [9] [10]

INFLATION / HOUSEHOLD ECONOMY

Weekly Price Indicator Shows 11.85 Percent Annual Rise

The new statistical release showed a 0.65 percent weekly increase, with household energy and food items driving changes.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, the Pakistan Bureau of Statistics released the Sensitive Price Indicator for the week ending Thursday, 22 October. The all-income-group index stood at 374.84 on a 2015–16 base and rose 0.65 percent against the previous week. Dawn, reporting the official release, calculated an annual rise of 11.85 percent.

The SPI follows the prices of 51 selected essential items in 50 markets across 17 cities. In the reported week, 19 items became more expensive, 12 became cheaper and 20 showed no change. Liquefied petroleum gas rose 22.44 percent week on week, chicken 12.20 percent and onions 4.19 percent; tomatoes, among other goods, recorded a weekly decline.

The SPI is a timely measure of price movements in a selected basket, not the same as the monthly Consumer Price Index. A week-on-week reading compares one reporting week with the preceding week; a year-on-year reading compares with the equivalent week one year earlier. Distinguishing the two prevents the false impression that all prices rose 11.85 percent in seven days.

BACKGROUND

The index is published by PBS and uses 2015–16 as its base. Its basket is deliberately narrower than a comprehensive measure of household consumption, making it useful for high-frequency monitoring rather than a substitute for annual or monthly inflation series.

ANALYSIS

Persistent increases in cooking fuel and staple foods can squeeze household budgets before they appear fully in other indicators. Policymakers must separate temporary item-specific shocks from general inflation persistence when evaluating price support, energy taxes and monetary conditions.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 SPI index: 374.84 for the week ended 22 October 2026.

02 Weekly change: +0.65%; annual change reported by Dawn: +11.85%.

03 The SPI tracks 51 items across 17 cities and 50 markets.

EXAM ANGLE / Economics — inflation measurement; General Science & Ability — interpreting percentage changes. [11] [12]

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INDUSTRIAL POLICY / INVESTMENT

Karachi Industrial Park Wins Federal Special Economic Zone Approval

The Board of Approvals also backed criteria for providing utilities and a public-sector industrial land lease policy in Punjab.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, the Board of Approvals for Special Economic Zones approved Karachi Industrial Park as a federal special economic zone. The eleventh board meeting was chaired by Finance Minister Muhammad Aurangzeb. The government described the proposed zone as a platform for export-oriented manufacturing, technology transfer, industrial value addition and employment.

The board also approved general eligibility criteria under the Special Economic Zones Act, 2012, for public funding of utility and allied services up to the designated zero point of privately established zones. According to the Press Information Department, the criteria are designed for case-by-case examination of roads, utilities and related infrastructure. A further approval concerned a land lease policy for public-sector zones and industrial estates in Punjab.

The approval is a regulatory step rather than evidence that all proposed factories, electricity connections or jobs already exist. The economic results depend on financing, serviced land, investor participation and compliance with the governing rules.

BACKGROUND

An SEZ is a geographically defined industrial area operating under a specific legal framework and administrative rules intended to attract investment. Benefits depend on the legal instruments and conditions applicable to each zone, rather than a general guarantee of investment.

ANALYSIS

The decision addresses an enduring barrier to industrialisation: firms cannot operate competitively when land, reliable energy, road access and predictable rules are unavailable. Monitoring should focus on actual occupancy, exports, cost recovery and jobs rather than counting approved zone titles.

Radio Pakistan separately confirmed the board's major decisions on the same date.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 The Board of Approvals approved Karachi Industrial Park as a federal SEZ.

02 The board's meeting was its eleventh, chaired by Muhammad Aurangzeb.

03 Utility-support criteria refer to the Special Economic Zones Act, 2012.

EXAM ANGLE / Economics — industrialisation and investment; Pakistan Affairs — export-led growth. [13] [14]

LAW / REGULATORY REFORM

Cabinet Panel Clears Overloading Penalties and Regulatory Drafts

A legislative committee backed road-safety fines, levy amendments and administrative rules, with further approvals still required.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, the Cabinet Committee on Disposal of Legislative Cases approved proposals to increase fines and penalties for overloaded vehicles. Federal Law and Justice Minister Azam Nazeer Tarar chaired the meeting. The Press Information Department said the panel also gave in-principle approval to the National Highways and Motorway Police Seniority Rules, 2026.

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BACKGROUND

A cabinet committee may screen or endorse draft rules and bills before the legal steps required for implementation are complete. The distinction between a committee recommendation, a law passed by a legislature and an enforceable rule matters when interpreting regulatory news.

ANALYSIS

Higher penalties may support road safety and protect public infrastructure, but their effectiveness will depend on consistent enforcement and due process. The simultaneous focus on levies and business registration shows how regulatory reform can connect administrative capacity with investor confidence.

The committee approved draft changes concerning the Petroleum Levy and Climate Support Levy, along with proposed rules for the Asaan Karobar Technical Unit and the Pakistan Regulatory Registry. The decisions covered transport enforcement, public finance and the systems through which businesses interact with regulators.

These were committee-level approvals, not a report of final enactment or the immediate commencement of every proposed provision. The ministry's release stated that the drafts and proposals would be forwarded to the relevant forums for additional legal and administrative proceedings. No specific new overloading-fine amount was stated in the official announcement, so no amount can responsibly be assigned.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 The cabinet committee approved proposals for higher vehicle-overloading penalties.

02 Drafts covered petroleum and climate support levies.

03 The approved proposals remained subject to further proceedings.

EXAM ANGLE / Governance & Public Administration — rule-making; Pakistan Affairs — transport regulation. [15] [16]

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02 WORLD

DIPLOMACY / ENERGY / GLOBAL HEALTH / ENVIRONMENT / GOVERNANCE

GLOBAL ECONOMY / ENERGY

Brent Oil Briefly Hits $115 Amid Regional Supply Fears

Renewed attacks and shipping risks raised concern about the price of energy reaching import-dependent economies.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, Brent crude futures touched $115 per barrel, the highest level reported since 4 May, as markets reacted to heightened security risks in the Middle East. Reuters reported that, at 11:38 GMT, Brent stood at $114.57 a barrel, up $1.40, or 1.2 percent, while US West Texas Intermediate futures stood at $100.95.

The immediate concern followed attacks linked to the conflict between the Houthi movement and Saudi Arabia and fears that regional escalation could further affect shipment routes. Market participants also weighed the risks to navigation around the Bab el-Mandeb passage and Hormuz. The price cited was an intraday observation, not the final settlement for the trading day.

Reuters also reported that environmental officials in the United Arab Emirates were responding to an oil spill off Umm Al Quwain, without identifying the tanker or its cause. That incident should not be conflated with the price rise. Both episodes nevertheless showed how regional instability can have separate trade, environmental and financial implications.

BACKGROUND

Brent is an internationally used oil price benchmark. Its movements affect import costs, but the final domestic effect depends on exchange rates, tax settings, retail-price decisions and the timing of shipments.

ANALYSIS

Oil-price shocks act through several channels: the external account, transport, food distribution and electricity generation. For importers such as Pakistan, more expensive energy can place upward pressure on the import bill and prices, although the magnitude cannot be known from a single intraday quote.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Brent reached $115 per barrel intraday on 23 October.

02 At 11:38 GMT, Reuters quoted Brent at $114.57 and WTI at $100.95.

03 An intraday high is not the same as a closing settlement.

EXAM ANGLE / International Relations — maritime security; Economics — supply shocks and imported inflation. [17] [18]

GLOBAL HEALTH / SCIENCE

WHO Reports Launch of Bundibugyo Vaccine Trial in Congo

The TUMAINI Phase 2/3 study began as public-health teams confronted a large Ebola outbreak across central Africa.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, the World Health Organization reported that the first participants had enrolled in the TUMAINI vaccine trial in Bunia, Democratic Republic of the Congo. The Phase 2/3 trial is

testing candidate vaccines against Bundibugyo virus disease, a form of Ebola disease for which WHO said no approved vaccine or specific treatment was then available.

BACKGROUND

Bundibugyo virus is one of the viruses capable of causing Ebola disease. It spreads between people through direct contact with infectious bodily fluids or contaminated materials, rather than routine casual proximity; early detection and safe clinical practices are therefore central to response.

ANALYSIS

The outbreak demonstrates how health-system capacity and regional cooperation are central to global security. Cross-border mobility makes laboratory readiness and transparent reporting essential. A successful trial could change future preparedness, but it must be judged by evidence rather than announcements.

WHO's report, using surveillance figures through 20 October, recorded 9,704 confirmed cases and 4,687 deaths in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, representing a crude case-fatality ratio of 48.3 percent. It identified cases in 66 health zones across eight provinces. Kenya had reported nine linked cases, including one death; Nigeria had reported an imported case in Abuja.

The launch of a clinical trial does not establish that a candidate vaccine is safe and effective. Researchers must examine clinical evidence before regulatory decisions can be made. WHO also stressed surveillance, contact tracing, infection prevention, care and communication, and advised against restrictions on travel or trade involving affected countries.

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THREE REVISION POINTS

01 TUMAINI Phase 2/3 trial enrolled participants in Bunia on 23 October.

02 WHO reported 9,704 DRC cases and 4,687 deaths as of 20 October.

03 WHO advised against travel and trade restrictions on affected countries.

EXAM ANGLE / General Science — infectious disease and vaccines; Current Affairs — global health governance. [19]

DIGITAL GOVERNANCE / CHILD RIGHTS

Greek Parliament Passes Social-Media Ban for Children Under 15

The new law will require age verification and is scheduled to take effect at the start of 2027.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, Greece's parliament passed legislation barring children below 15 from social-media platforms. AFP reported that Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis's New Democracy party used its parliamentary majority after a debate stretching from Thursday into Friday. The Greek parliament's legislative record independently lists 23 October as the date of passage.

The reported law is scheduled to take effect on 1 January 2027. It provides for age-verification requirements and penalties when platforms fail to comply. The opposition Pasok party abstained after proposing a different threshold, while other opposition groups voted against the measure. This indicates that concern for child safety did not produce consensus over the most appropriate restriction.

Supporters cited risks linked to excessive platform use, while critics and civil-liberties advocates questioned proportionality and whether technical age checks can be both effective and privacy-preserving. The debate therefore concerned competing public values as well as digital enforcement.

BACKGROUND

Age assurance can include age verification and estimation methods. The technical design matters: strong identity checks can deter under-age access but may impose privacy costs, while weaker systems can be easily bypassed.

ANALYSIS

Greece offers a useful comparison for debates over platform responsibility, freedom of expression and protection of minors. The measure's long-term significance will depend on how the rules are enforced, whether compliance is measurable and what safeguards protect children's personal data.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 The Greek legislature recorded passage on 23 October 2026.

02 The reported age threshold is under 15.

03 AFP reported an intended start date of 1 January 2027.

EXAM ANGLE / Political Science — rights and regulation; Governance — age verification and platform accountability. [20] [21] [22]

CLIMATE RISKS / DISASTER RESPONSE

Typhoon Champi Disrupts Taiwan Travel and Public Services

The island closed schools and offices, suspended flights and evacuated vulnerable communities as the storm moved past.

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On Friday, 23 October 2026, Taiwan shut schools and many offices and cancelled hundreds of flights as Typhoon Champi passed near the island. Associated Press reported the cancellation of all 262 domestic flights and 669 international flights in its Friday account. Authorities evacuated more than 2,600 people from exposed mountainous locations.

AP said the typhoon had earlier reached maximum sustained winds of 298 kilometres an hour before weakening to 155 kilometres an hour near Taiwan. Its wide circulation exposed coastal areas to powerful winds and heavy rain even as forecasters expected the centre to remain offshore. The report noted one death from a wave-related incident the previous day and more than 170 injuries reported by Friday.

The weather system also affected parts of Japan and the Philippines, where authorities restricted journeys and prepared vulnerable settlements. Flight cancellations, evacuation decisions and infrastructure safeguards showed the value of early warning even when a storm does not strike directly over a city.

BACKGROUND

Typhoons are tropical cyclones in the western North Pacific. Their effects are not limited to the eye or landfall location: rain bands, waves, storm surge and wind fields can threaten a large area.

ANALYSIS

The policy issue extends beyond meteorology. Risk communication, transport contingency plans, resilient power infrastructure and evacuation logistics determine whether warnings can protect lives and livelihoods. Storm losses cannot be attributed to climate change from one event alone without an attribution study.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 AP recorded 262 domestic and 669 international flight cancellations on Friday.

02 More than 2,600 people were evacuated from vulnerable areas.

03 Storm impacts can extend well beyond the centre's track.

EXAM ANGLE / General Science — tropical cyclones; Environmental Studies — disaster-risk reduction. [23]

CYBERSECURITY / WARFARE

Ukraine Warns of Intensified Attacks on Its Digital Infrastructure

Kyiv's prime minister said data centres and government networks were under pressure alongside energy infrastructure.

On Friday, 23 October 2026, Ukrainian Prime Minister Sergiy Koretskyi said Russia was attacking Ukraine's digital infrastructure with intensity comparable to strikes on its electricity sector. Reuters reported his statement at 14:22 UTC, or 19:22 Pakistan Standard Time, within the day's reporting window.

BACKGROUND

Digital infrastructure includes data centres, connectivity and the systems that support public administration. Damage may result from physical strikes as well as intrusions into networks, which require different defences and evidence standards.

ANALYSIS

Modern conflict blurs the distinction between military targets, civilian services and information systems. Governments need recovery capacity, network security and service continuity. The case also raises issues of attribution: officials' warnings are important intelligence, but public proof of particular cyber operations may remain incomplete.

Koretskyi said ten data centres in Kyiv had been struck during the preceding month. He also warned that cyberattacks supported by artificial-intelligence methods were increasing against government information systems and businesses. The prime minister called on public organisations to develop dedicated cybersecurity teams and said key digital agencies had begun using AI-based defences.

The reported numbers and allegations came from the Ukrainian government. Reuters placed them within the wider war, noting strikes on energy, logistics and other infrastructure. Specific claims about attack origins, damage and cyber techniques should be understood as Kyiv's account unless corroborated by technical investigation.

THREE REVISION POINTS

01 Reuters dated the statement to 23 October at 14:22 UTC.

02 Ukraine's prime minister reported ten Kyiv data centres struck in the prior month.

03 He urged agencies to establish dedicated cybersecurity teams.

EXAM ANGLE / International Relations — hybrid conflict; Governance — cybersecurity and critical infrastructure. [24]

Next Seven Days / 25–30 October 2026

26 OCT State Bank of Pakistan monetary policy decision and briefing, as scheduled in the FY27 MPC calendar. [25]

27 OCT SBP analysts' briefing following the 26 October monetary policy meeting. [25]

28 OCT UN Sixth Committee: scheduled interactive dialogue with members of the International Law Commission. [26]

29 OCT UN General Assembly: scheduled introduction of the International Court of Justice report. [26]

30 OCT UN Sixth Committee: scheduled statement by the President of the International Court of Justice. [26]

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03 GENERAL KNOWLEDGE

18 VERIFIED FACTS / PAKISTAN & WORLD

01 DIPLOMACY

R4 consists of Türkiye, Egypt, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia. [1]

02 DIPLOMACY

Four additional European countries joined Istanbul's larger consultation on 23 October. [2]

03 DIPLOMACY

The Strait of Hormuz was explicitly discussed in the R4 ministerial statement. [1]

04 DEFENCE

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement was signed by three countries in August 2026. [7]

05 DEFENCE

Türkiye's ratification was pending when Pakistan's Foreign Office spoke on 23 October. [7]

06 AGRICULTURE

Pakistan's announced indicative 2027 wheat price was Rs4,500 per 40 kg. [9]

07 AGRICULTURE

The announced wheat benchmark exceeded the earlier figure by Rs1,000 per 40 kg. [9]

08 PRICES

PBS put the SPI index for the week ended 22 October at 374.84. [11]

09 PRICES

SPI rose 0.65% week on week in the official 23 October release. [11]

10 PRICES

PBS monitors 51 essential items in 50 markets across 17 cities. [12]

11 INDUSTRY

Karachi Industrial Park was approved as a federal special economic zone. [13]

12 INDUSTRY

SEZ infrastructure criteria cited Pakistan's Special Economic Zones Act, 2012. [13]

13 LAW

The legislative panel backed new penalties for road-vehicle overloading. [15]

14 ENERGY

Brent crude briefly reached $115 per barrel on 23 October 2026. [17]

15 HEALTH

WHO's 23 October report counted 9,704 confirmed Bundibugyo cases in the DRC as of 20 October. [19]

16 HEALTH

The TUMAINI candidate-vaccine trial was launched in Bunia. [19]

17 TECH

Greece's under-15 social-media bill passed parliament on 23 October 2026. [21]

18 CLIMATE

AP reported 262 domestic Taiwan flight cancellations during Typhoon Champi. [23]

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04 FIVE TERMS

PERMANENT CONCEPTS / FIVE DISCIPLINES

01 Judicial review

A court's power to evaluate whether laws and government acts comply with a constitution. It can render conflicting legislation or executive measures inapplicable where the constitutional system grants that authority.

WHY IT MATTERS / This concept helps explain checks and balances, limits on executive action and constitutional remedies.

EXAMPLE / US Supreme Court: Marbury v. Madison, 1803, established judicial review in federal constitutional practice.

AUTHORITATIVE REFERENCE [27]

02 Diplomatic immunity

A set of legal protections enjoyed by accredited diplomatic agents under international law. It protects the independent performance of diplomatic functions, with important distinctions among personal inviolability, jurisdictional immunity and possible waiver.

WHY IT MATTERS / It helps distinguish protection of official relations from impunity or exemption from international obligations.

EXAMPLE / Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations, signed in 1961 and in force from 24 April 1964.

AUTHORITATIVE REFERENCE [28]

03 Fiscal federalism

The organisation of public revenue, spending responsibilities and transfers between levels of government. It examines how fiscal assignments and intergovernmental grants affect service delivery, incentives and accountability.

WHY IT MATTERS / It is central to evaluating fiscal autonomy, equalisation and federal–provincial resource sharing.

EXAMPLE / Pakistan's 2009 Seventh NFC Award redistributed divisible-pool resources through a multi-factor provincial formula.

AUTHORITATIVE REFERENCE [29]

04 Ombudsman

An independent public grievance mechanism that investigates allegations of maladministration in institutions within its mandate. It offers an accessible administrative remedy, often through inquiry and recommendations or orders under its governing law.

WHY IT MATTERS / The term connects accountability, complaint-handling and citizens' access to remedies.

EXAMPLE / Pakistan established the federal Wafaqi Mohtasib office on 24 January 1983.

AUTHORITATIVE REFERENCE [30]

05 El Niño–Southern Oscillation

A recurring interaction between tropical Pacific sea-surface temperatures and atmospheric circulation, with warm El Niño and cool La Niña phases. These phases influence regional rainfall, temperature and hazards in different parts of the world.

WHY IT MATTERS / Understanding ENSO assists analysis of climate variability, forecasting and food-security risks.

EXAMPLE / NOAA records the exceptionally strong 1997–98 El Niño and transition to La Niña conditions during 1998.

AUTHORITATIVE REFERENCE [31]

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05 PRACTICE

15 MULTIPLE-CHOICE QUESTIONS / ONE BEST ANSWER

Q01. Which four states form the R4 group?

A. Türkiye, Egypt, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia
B. Türkiye, Qatar, Pakistan, Indonesia
C. Pakistan, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Egypt
D. Egypt, Jordan, Pakistan, Türkiye

Q02. What is the indicative 2027 wheat price announced in Pakistan?

A. Rs3,500 per maund
B. Rs4,500 per maund
C. Rs5,000 per maund
D. Rs4,000 per maund

Q03. Which indicator is published weekly by Pakistan Bureau of Statistics?

A. GDP deflator
B. Balance of payments
C. Sensitive Price Indicator
D. Industrial output census

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Q04. Which international organisation issued the 23 October Bundibugyo update?

A. UNESCO
B. WTO
C. UNCTAD
D. World Health Organization

Q05. The Greek ban adopted on 23 October applies to which age group?

A. Children below 15
B. Children below 18
C. Children below 13
D. Children below 16

Q06. Which project received federal SEZ status from Pakistan's Board of Approvals?

A. Gwadar Free Zone
B. Karachi Industrial Park
C. Rashakai Economic Zone
D. Port Qasim Naval Yard

Q07. The Makkah defence pact spokesperson said ratification was pending in:

A. Saudi Arabia
B. Pakistan
C. Türkiye
D. Egypt

Q08. Which oil benchmark briefly reached $115 per barrel on 23 October?

A. Dubai crude
B. OPEC basket
C. WTI crude

D. Brent crude

Q09. Which body approved proposals to increase penalties for vehicle overloading?

A. Cabinet Committee on Disposal of Legislative Cases
B. Senate Standing Committee on Defence
C. National Finance Commission
D. Election Commission of Pakistan

Q10. The 23 October SPI release reported what weekly percentage change?

A. A fall of 0.65%
B. A rise of 0.65%
C. A rise of 11.85%
D. A fall of 11.85%

Q11. WHO reported that TUMAINI was launched in which city?

A. Kinshasa
B. Kigali
C. Bunia
D. Nairobi

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Q12. Which authority in Taiwan cancelled 262 domestic flights during Champi?

A. Central Bank
B. Parliament
C. Supreme Court
D. Transport ministry

Q13. Judicial review was established in US federal practice by which 1803 case?

A. Marbury v. Madison
B. Brown v. Board
C. McCulloch v. Maryland
D. Gibbons v. Ogden

Q14. Under the Vienna Convention, diplomatic immunity principally protects:

A. Private commercial investments
B. Performance of diplomatic functions
C. Unrestricted political campaigning
D. All domestic legal claims permanently

Q15. Fiscal federalism primarily examines:

A. Ocean transport routes
B. Central-bank currency issuance only
C. Public finances across levels of government
D. International humanitarian law only

Answer Key / Explanations

CORRECT OPTION / ONE-SENTENCE EXPLANATION / SOURCE

01 A The R4 members are Türkiye, Egypt, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia. [1]

02 B Radio Pakistan reported the indicative price as Rs4,500 per 40 kilograms. [9]

03 C PBS publishes the SPI for a basket of essential items every week. [11]

04 D WHO issued the situation update and described the TUMAINI trial. [19]

05 A The law passed by Greece applies to children under 15. [20]

06 B The board approved Karachi Industrial Park as a federal SEZ. [13]

07 C The 23 October report said Türkiye was continuing domestic ratification. [7]

08 D Reuters reported a Brent intraday high of $115 a barrel. [17]

09 A The Cabinet Committee on Disposal of Legislative Cases cleared the proposals. [15]

10 B PBS reported a 0.65% week-on-week increase, not the annual rate. [11]

11 C The first participants enrolled in Bunia, Democratic Republic of the Congo. [19]

12 D AP attributed 262 domestic cancellations to Taiwan's transport ministry. [23]

13 A The US National Archives identifies Marbury v. Madison with judicial review. [27]

14 B The diplomatic framework protects missions' functions while recognising exceptions and waiver. [28]

15 C Fiscal federalism concerns revenues, spending and transfers between levels of government. [32]

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EDITOR
S. ALI HASSAN SARGANA

06 REFERENCES

NUMBERED SOURCES / OPEN LINKS

01 Republic of Türkiye MFA, R4 joint statement, 23 Oct 2026

02 Pakistan PID, ministerial meeting, 23 Oct 2026

03 Dawn, Istanbul ministerial talks, 23 Oct 2026

04 Radio Pakistan, SBP policy rate, 14 Sep 2026

05 Business Recorder, USD/PKR interbank, 23 Oct 2026

06 Mettis Global, KSE-100 close, 23 Oct 2026

07 Dawn, Makkah defence pact ratification, 23 Oct 2026

08 Pakistan PID, Dar meets Hakan Fidan, 23 Oct 2026

09 Radio Pakistan, wheat price decision, 23 Oct 2026

10 Dawn, indicative wheat price, 23 Oct 2026

11 Pakistan Bureau of Statistics, SPI release, 23 Oct 2026

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